



Ever since India became independent there have been Jeremiahs prophesying that it will fall apart. With each crisis India has faced during the 60 turbulent years of its Independence, their dismal voices have risen only for them to be proved false prophets.

The appalling violence of Partition appeared to threaten the unity of India from the start. But then those who feared that the desire to take revenge on Muslims for Partition would lead to an unsustainable militant Hindu state found that the shock of Gandhi's assassination brought India back to its senses. There was the trouble over language, wisely as it turned out, resolved by the creation of linguistic states. Many thought that was a recipe for disintegration, but they have been proved wrong.

In Nehru's later days, the nervous question asked over and over again, was "After Nehru who?" During the Chinese war, Nehru himself, who had done so much to establish a stable India, feared that Assam would be lost when the Chinese invaded. Assam and the rest of the North-East is still with India and Lal Bahadur Shastri followed by Indira Gandhi gave a resounding reply to the doubters who had asked "After Nehru who?" During Indira Gandhi's Emergency, many

prophesied the end of Indian democracy, and I, for one, believe that it would have broken India because it can only be held together if it's ruled with a fairly light rein, which only democracy can do. But then Indira confounded the prophets of doom by calling for an election and accepting defeat. This has been the hallmark of Indian democracy—the acceptance of the voters' decision, and the peaceful transfer of power. So many countries have been destabilised by governing

HARMONY OF FAITH: A Hindu temple and a mosque